

Ohio River Trail Council



1100 Pennsylvania Av
Monaca, Pa 15061
724-728-2625

MINUTES

DATE 3-18-14

TIME 3:00 PM

PLACE MONACA HOLIDAY INN EXPRESS

MEETING CALLED BY	Dr. Vincent Troia
TYPE OF MEETING	Quarterly
FACILITATOR	Dr. Vincent Troia
NOTE TAKER	Donna Campbell, Secretary

Attendees: Vincent Troia, CEO ORTC; Adam Mattis, DCNR; Kevin Kopa, Bechtel/Kopac Insurance; Phyllis McChesney, Montour Trail Council; Jack Manning, ORTC; Norm Ely, Rochester Twp.; Sara Walfoort, SPC; Donna Campbell, ORTC Secretary; Mario Leone, Monaca Borough Mgr.; Bill Sweterlitsch, Coordinator Coraopolis; John Orndorff, Sewickley Valley Community Fund; Nathan Peluso, Towne Centre Associates; Mindy McKee, MSM ORTC; Greg Kalamasz, ORTC

DISCUSSION	Dr. Vincent Troia called the meeting to order and we opened with the approval of last meeting's minutes. Everyone present introduced themselves. Dr. Vincent Troia then reviewed Dr. Troia's newly named "ABC Initiative." The Action Based Counties (ABC) Initiative includes the counties of Allegheny, Beaver, and Columbiana. This project is designed to close the trail gap between the Little Beaver Creek Trail and the Montour Trail via the proposed Ohio River Trail. Dr. Troia reviewed the map of all trails, completed and incomplete.
DISCUSSION	The Ohio River Water Trail was approved as a state water trail in January 2013. Dr. Troia's map showed an overall view of the complete project which runs from the Point in Pittsburgh, PA to the Ohio State Line. ORTC received a \$20,000 grant from the Port of Pittsburgh and the \$11,000 from the National Park Service to create the project and map. Pictures in brochure show that the Ohio River is no longer primarily "Industrial". The new launch at Freedom, PA was viewed indicating river access under the Norfolk Southern Railroad tracks. Bridgewater crossing also shows a dual trailhead with river and land trail access. Pictures of the Bridgewater Riverfront crossing and New Brighton Boat launch were reviewed as well. Dr. Troia announced that a new trailhead will be placed along the river in Beaver, PA and it too will be a dual trailhead. Other areas of the river were viewed including the restricted areas near the Shippingport Power Plant and the Montgomery Dam, and the scenic areas of Georgetown and Phyllis Island and Lock 57 Park (dual trailhead). Dr. Troia continued to review the trail along the Little Beaver Creek indicating the location of Eagle Rapid, listed as a Class I rapid.
DISCUSSION	Dr. Vincent Troia reviewed the Ohio River Greenway Trail project Phase I, coordinated by Bill Sweterlitsch and Lance Welliver. Phase I travels through Coraopolis, PA and ends at the Sewickley Bridge. Phyllis McChesney of the Montour Trail Council added that the trail traverses the Montour Junction Sports Complex property to the Neville Island Bridge and connects with the Coraopolis project. Dr. Vincent Troia stated that Duquesne Light is in favor of the Phase I project. The Owner of Tri State Hose Supply, also located in that area prefers that we utilize the Penn DOT right of way, which is feasible.

	A "feeder trail" from Ambulance Way to the Sewickley Bridge was reviewed. A representation of the Moon Township Riverfront Park showed proposed trail alignment through the park with fishing piers and river access points. A \$400,000 grant for Phase I Construction Costs from TCSP and another \$200,000 grant from Act 13 will help defray the cost of Phase I. Sara Walfoort asked if crossing from the feeder trail onto the Sewickley Bridge would be handled with a Pedestrian Call Button. Dr. Vincent Troia stated the call button exists at each end. The construction of this section of trail could have potentially saved a life in light of a recent accident at the intersection of the Sewickley bridge and Route 51.
DISCUSSION	Phase II of the Greenway Trail coordinated by John Orndorff was then reviewed showing a section of Bike Route A from Glen Osborne to Leetsdale. John said he is also looking at "further up the River". Dr. Troia reminded him that that portion of the project is being handled by Friends of the Riverfront. Further discussion reviewed the trail following the Sewickley Bridge sidewalk on the South Side across to Edgeworth and Leetsdale. This part of the trail will be "bikeway" because the dedicated trail route through Crescent Township is challenging. The map showed the trail from Ambridge to South Heights with a ramp down the hill to the River and a connection to Old Economy Village. Jack Manning reported a plan for a new "boutique" Hotel being constructed in Ambridge. The Ohio River trail was referenced when feasibility was being done for the Hotel. Phase II costs have not been determined at this time. A study for the South route has been completed but Dr. Troia feels the North trail extension is a better option. Friends of the Riverfront will continue the project beyond Coraopolis, PA. to Pittsburgh. Dr. Troia presented a PowerPoint presentation to Rochester Twp reviewing the trail project and a wonderful riverfront master plan completed 12 years ago showing trail plans near the Norfolk Southern rail bed along the river in Rochester Twp. The ¾-mile section owned by the railroad is presently a hindrance to completing the trail. A review of the Master Site completed in 2002 by Pashek and Associates reveals "plenty of space on a beautiful piece of property for developing a trail" complete with parking, shelters, docks and piers. There will be a 10-foot sidewalk across the new Veterans Bridge that can be used to cross the Beaver River to Fallston. Sara Walfoort asked what the alternative would be to Norfolk Southern property use. Dr. Troia explained that a boardwalk could be built. A trail agreement would protect the railroad from liability but does not stop people from filing suit, wasting the railroad's time in court. Dr. Troia suggested that perhaps the property could be purchased, but most likely, the route will need to be diverted along existing Bike Route A. Sara Walfoort suggested pursuing a "Plan B". She stated that DEP has approved boardwalk access in the past. The Millvale Trail is a prime example of a precedent-setting boardwalk. The boardwalk runs to the community of Millvale is somewhat suspended over the water. The Mon Wharf switchback is also a precedent. Adam Mattis of DCNR stated his concern of the cost to construct a ¾ mile boardwalk. He explained that the Millvale Boardwalk is only about ¼ mile long and cost over 2 million dollars. The debated portion of this trail would eventually connect to the rail-trail in Beaver Falls. Dr. Troia added that Route 65 is part of Bike Route A and the YMCA is one of our trailheads. Project budget stages were reviewed along with project costs for the Monaca-Rochester Phase.
DISCUSSION	The northern terminus of the trail was then reviewed showing the proposed trail from Midland to the State line with project costs to be determined. Meetings about the connections in Ohioville, PA, Columbiana County and privately owned property of H R Lewis and Vodrey, which follows the Little Beaver Creek and onto Lisbon OH are being coordinated by Dottie Betz, chairman at the Columbiana County Park District. The North Country Hiking trail also crosses this phase of the trail system.
DISCUSSION	The center section of the trail was briefly reviewed. This portion of the trail encompasses Monaca, Center Township, Hopewell, Aliquippa and South Heights along the brownfield.
DISCUSSION	A Regional Trail Network Initiative known as the Power of 32+ is working at the regional level. The project website is found at www.GoToTrails.info (Do not use Internet Explorer). The Pittsburgh to Ashtabula Trail presently utilizes the proposed Raccoon Creek Greenway and Dr. Troia indicated that this would include Raccoon Creek State Park and would make a beautiful loop with the Ohio River Trail. "Cleve-burgh," Cleveland to Pittsburgh metropolis was also briefly discussed. Dr. Troia stated we usually do not review going north since we have the GAP trail going south but the Underground Railroad Bicycle Route is a great bikeway from Pittsburgh to Erie!

DISCUSSION	Major Grants and Donations to date were reviewed including: First Energy \$15,000 DCNR C2P2 \$60,000 TCSP \$200,000 The TAP Grant application due on the 4th of April 2014 – Moon Township is applying for this and Dr. Troia would like them to include the Ohio River Trail Project in their grant The Power of 32+ is applying for a Regional TIGER Grant, Dr. Troia asked Moon Township to participate in this effort to include completing Phase 1 and possibly Phase 2.
DISCUSSION	The Brownfields Remediation Project coordinated by Mario Leone and Jack Manning is an area wide planning project encompassing Midland, Monaca, Aliquippa and Coraopolis focusing on Riverfront redevelopment. A target area is the Montour Brownfield near Neville Island Bridge. Mario Leone reported on The Community Roundtable, which picked locations eligible to move on to the next level for redevelopment including Flint Michigan, Atlanta, GA and Monaca, PA. Jay Williams, Secretary of Economic Development was available for an intense day of breakout sessions accessing manufacturing clusters across the country. If defined as eligible we can receive additional funds from the EPA. The Obama Administration is pushing for this funding and he is confident we can be selected. Targeted cluster areas include Youngstown OH, Allegheny County and Beaver County into West Virginia. To get the designation you must have the educational component coupled with manufacturing. We have Carnegie Mellon University and local manufacturing along with a strong tri-state lobbying group. Jack Manning added that this is not Congressional earmark funds. The money falls outside these funds eliminating the necessity of Congressional oversight making the process easier. Dr. Troia stated that brownfield remediation is essential as many of our trails traverse the brownfields and it makes good sense.
DISCUSSION	Bike racks on the BCTA busses were discussed. Sara explained that BCTA informed her that every bus capable of carrying a bike has a rack installed on the bus. BCTA presently does not have any busses with bike racks. Racks cannot be installed on coach busses because there is no way to mount them. Port Authority and New Castle busses do have them. Dr. Troia asked if seats could be removed and racks placed inside. Sara explained that BCTA is very proud of some of the things going on in Rochester and recently they are talking with a different level of enthusiasm about bicycling. Rack n' Roll in Pittsburgh is the project enabling busses to carry two bikes on their racks. Sara stated that routes to Pittsburgh would need racks and perhaps BCTA could swap busses on routes that need rack accommodation.
DISCUSSION	Dr. Troia mentioned the License plate program available with ORTC membership. A \$50.00 membership level entitles the member to a license plate, hat or t-shirt.
DISCUSSION	ORTC Open House will be held at CCBC Building 9, room 9103 on May 1, 2014 from 3:00 to 7:00 pm. Light refreshments will be served. Volunteers are asked to arrive at 2:00 pm for setup.
DISCUSSION	Gear and Cheer Music Festival will be held July 12, 2014 at the Brady's Run Park Lodge. Sponsorship opportunities are available, with Laura Tocci, of the Beaver County Bar Association, giving \$1,000.00 so far. Lots of events are planned, including free events such as Live Music, Arts and Crafts, Road Cycling, Kayaking and Canoeing, Paddle boarding, Outdoor Clubs and Trail Organizations. Events with fees include Beer and Wine tasting, Rock Wall Climbing, 5K Run Walk, Mountain Biking, Kayak Race and a Fishing Tournament. Dr. Troia has scheduled a new band this year, the Delaneys. Please refer to the website for more information at www.ohiorivertrail.org or follow the festival on Facebook.
DISCUSSION	Dr. Troia then opened the meeting to questions or comments. Bill Sweterlitsch said he has been sending e-mails for status on the key Moon Twp. project. Mr. Slagel has approved the Coraopolis RFQ but Doniele Russell informed him there is a hold-up above him. Their approval is necessary to start. He stated that the Park and Ride at Moon Township is a nice spot and is underserved.

	Sara asked him if he has reviewed Groveton. This area ties in with the project and they have great interest in the ORT connection into Pittsburgh. She said this would be a "cool development" if Coraopolis could get trail completion to Groveton, backtracking to the Neville Island Bridge, down Neville Island to Fleming Bridge. Near Rocky's Restaurant there is a tiny little road to get you to the McKees Rocks Intermodal facility of CSX and the Trinity Project with CSX is entertaining an access point that could contribute to the value of the Coraopolis trail. This was just announced at an open house a few months ago that was not in Friends of the Riverfront original study with improvement from McKees Rocks out to the end of the industrial park that currently exists in Preston near where Chartiers Creek meets the Ohio River. A great connection could even be developed westward along Chartiers Creek. Sara said she bikes to work, commuting from McKees Rocks along Center Ave to Church to Lincoln and it is a great route. Dr. Troia asked if there was a North route. Sara stated there is a Waste Water facility there, which is protected because of "911." This impedes a bike route on the North Side of the Ohio River. Dr. Troia suggested a feasibility study and discussed connection opportunities from McKees Rocks to Sewickley. Bill Sweterlitsch commented that the Bellevue Police department is advocating FOR the trail, however the Borough Manager was in question. Jack Manning stated then new Manager is more interested in the project. Sara commented that bicycles are permitted to use 79 Bridge and that could be an optional route. Bicycle activity is prohibited on interstates unless specifically permitted and this is a permitted area.
DISCUSSION	Phyllis McChesney of the Montour Trail Council gave the group an update on the Sports Legacy Project. She said that nothing will happen until 2015. Their group does not have permission to clear near the River yet. This should come closer to summer 2014. A Superfund clean-up site is scheduled again for this year at mile point ½ mile from the start of the Montour Trail. They must dig down and take dirt out which will close the trail when work is in progress.
DISCUSSION	Greg Kalamasz asked if anyone has approached Shell Corp. for funds. They have been performing engineering for reconfiguration of intersections down route 18 to Raccoon Creek. Also perhaps we should contact representatives about property where the demolished Humane Society building was located. At one time Center Twp. had a plan that designated a Riverfront Park near here. Midland to the Community Park in Ohioville was also performing core samples along the road due to a slide near the river. If we contacted them in their planning maybe, we could get trail access along that route. Sara stated that is more of a "Main Street movement". Truck traffic in that area is too high and PennDOT is not receptive because of this. Sara also informed the group that 85% of PennDOT's money has already been diverted to bridges. She added that unfortunately at this time it is difficult to get PennDOT to work with us unless these proposals are already in their plan. Sara gave Greg names of persons for him to check and ask questions. Sara also suggests checking the abandoned trolley and rail lines as another option. Dr. Troia asked Sara what PennDOT has posted for Share-the-Road bikeway's speed limit. Sara informed him 40 to 45 MPH.
DISCUSSION	Bill Sweterlitsch asked for a current Area Winery and brewery list. Dr. Troia said he would send Bill another copy.
DISCUSSION	The Water trail website has been completed. Information can be viewed www.water.ohiorivertrail.org
DISCUSSION	Meeting was adjourned by Dr. Vincent Troia at 4.59 pm.
DISCUSSION	Next Meeting April 15, 2014. 2pm.